the right thing by pushing the liquid propulsion system. So, have I forgiven him for transferring me when the Vikas project was nearing completion? No. Call me mean if you want. Nothing; no confession, no apology could dilute my resolve to get the Vikas engine tested and running.

SEP agreed to ground-test the engine, but before signing the test contract, a team from the French agency would inspect the engine, the records and the processes followed. This would include perusal of instruction records, non-conformance reports and approvals by various boards.

Record keeping was not one of ISRO's high points, but thanks to our Vernon exposure, the Vikas team had meticulously documented every step and preserved all papers. The SEP team stayed in Trivandrum for two weeks, and were convinced about our work. Later, some of the French scientists told us that they were surprised at our efficiency and speed in which we put together the Vikas engine.

We had collaborated with them in Vernon and had showcased our skills, but it appeared there were still some who found it hard to believe that Indians could actually put together a liquid propulsion engine. Once convinced, the French had other plans for ISRO, which had already delivered, to SEP's satisfaction, pressure transducers for their rocket engines. A scientist told me that now SEP considered outsourcing the manufacturing of its Viking engines to ISRO. But the European Space Agency regulation states that 90% of the cost of any space science project should be spent within the member countries.

ISRO signed the contract with SEP for ground-testing Vikas. We were to pay Rs 1 crore to SEP, and Rs 60 lakhs would go towards propellant cost. We had to take care of the packaging and transport of the engine to France and back, and bear the other expenses of the Indian team in Vernon.

On the technology side, this was a big test for me. During the initial stages of negotiating the test contract, months before U R Rao took over as the ISRO chairman, Dhawan had called me.

'How confident are you about the test results?

'100 per cent,' I lied.